Speak Ghana

Reconnect. Speak. Thrive.

Twi Alphabet & Sounds

Twi Atwerɛdeɛ ne Nnyegyeeɛ

The Building Blocks of the Twi Language

Figure 1: Twi Atwerɛdeɛ: The Twi Alphabet A-Y

Akwaaba!

Welcome to your first real step in speaking Twi!

Asante Twi, which is a dialect of Akan, is a phonetic language. This means you read words exactly as they are written. Once you master the sounds of the letters, reading and writing become easy and natural.

Twi has **22 letters** in its alphabet (compared to English's 26). This chapter teaches you these letters, their sounds, and how they combine into syllables. Mastering them is your first step to speaking and understanding Asante Twi confidently.

Don't worry, we will learn them slowly and with fun.

Why the Alphabet Matters

When you know the letters and how they sound:

- You can read signs, songs, Bible verses, and text messages in Twi.
- You can write your name, family names, and short notes.
- You will sound more natural when speaking.
- You will understand the difference between words that look similar but mean different things.

The Asante Twi alphabet uses a modified Latin script. It includes:

- **7 vowels** (Ɛnne nnyegyeeɛ): Actually, Asante Twi has 10 vowel sounds, however only 7 are represented orthographically.
- **15 consonants** (Anom nnyegyeeɛ), Plus digraphs, where two letters are represented with only one sound.

Let's meet the complete Twi alphabet, all 22 letters!

Complete Twi Alphabet Chart (A-Y)

Letter	Name	Pronunciation	Example Word (Meaning)
A a	a	like 'a' in "father"	abɛ (palm-nut)
B b	b	like 'b' in "boy"	bankye (cassava)
D d	d	like 'd' in "dog"	din (name)
E e	e	like 'e' in "say" (but shorter)	efie (house)
Ɛ ɛ	ɛ	like 'e' in "bed" (open mouth)	ɛyɛ (it is)
F f	f	like 'f' in "fun"	fa (take)
G g	g	like 'g' in "go"	Ghana (Ghana)
H h	h	like 'h' in "hat"	hanam (prey)
I i	i	like 'ee' in "see" (but shorter)	efie (home)
K k	k	like 'k' in "key"	kasa (speak / language)
L l	l	like 'l' in "love"	lɔre (lorry - borrowed word)
M m	m	like 'm' in "man"	me (me / my)
N n	n	like 'n' in "no"	na (and / or)
O o	o	like 'o' in "go" (round mouth)	obi (someone)
Ɔ ɔ	ɔ	like 'aw' in "law" (open mouth)	ɔdɔ (love)
P p	p	like 'p' in "pen"	papa (father / good)
R r	r	like 'r' in "run" (lightly rolled)	Roma (Rome)
S s	s	like 's' in "sun"	sukuu (school)
T t	t	like 't' in "top"	te (hear / live / rent)
U u	u	like 'oo' in "food" (shorter)	U (letter name only)
W w	w	like 'w' in "win"	wo (you / your)
Y y	y	like 'y' in "yes"	yɛ (do / make / be)

Complete Alphabet List (All 22 Letters)

A, B, D, E, Ɛ, F, G, H, I, K, L, M, N, O, Ɔ, P, R, S, T, U, W, Y

Count them: 22 letters! Notice there is no C, J, Q, V, X, or Z in the Twi alphabet. When you see these in borrowed words, they are pronounced according to Twi sound patterns.

Special Letters – Ɛ and Ɔ

These two letters are the most important to master because they change meaning completely!

Letter	Sound	Example Pairs
Ɛ ɛ	bed (short e)	ɛyɛ (it is) vs eye (eye)
Ɔ ɔ	law (aw)	ɔdɔ (love) vs Odo (name)

Practice these pairs out loud 5 times each:

- **e vs ɛ:** eye (eye) vs ɛyɛ (it is)
- **o vs ɔ:** obi (someone) vs ɔdɔ (love)

The Sounds of Twi – Vowels and Consonants

Now that you know the alphabet, let's look a little deeper at how Twi sounds are made.

Twi Vowel Sounds (Ɛnne nnyegyeeɛ)

Twi has 10 vowel sounds but we write 7 (a, e, ɛ, i, o, ɔ, u), more than English! This is why some words may sound strange at first. The sounds (ɪ, ʊ, æ) are also vowel sounds but we do not write them separately.

Vowel	Sounds Like	Examples (nhwɛsoɔ)
i	ee in "see" (but shorter)	sika (money), bisa (ask), didi (eat)
ɪ	i in "sit"	sekan (knife), nante (walk)
u	oo in "food" (shorter)	duku (headwrap), banku (banku)
ʊ	u in "put"	ɛpo (ocean), nnwom (songs)
e	ey in "they" (shorter)	efie (house), ewiase (world)
ɛ	e in "bed"	ɛdan (building), ɔbrɛ (tiredness)
o	o in "go"	owuo (death), odwan (sheep)
ɔ	aw in "law"	ɔdɔ (love), ɔkyena (tomorrow)
æ	a in "cat"	ani (eye), aburo (corn)
a	a in "father"	abaa (stick), aboa (animal)

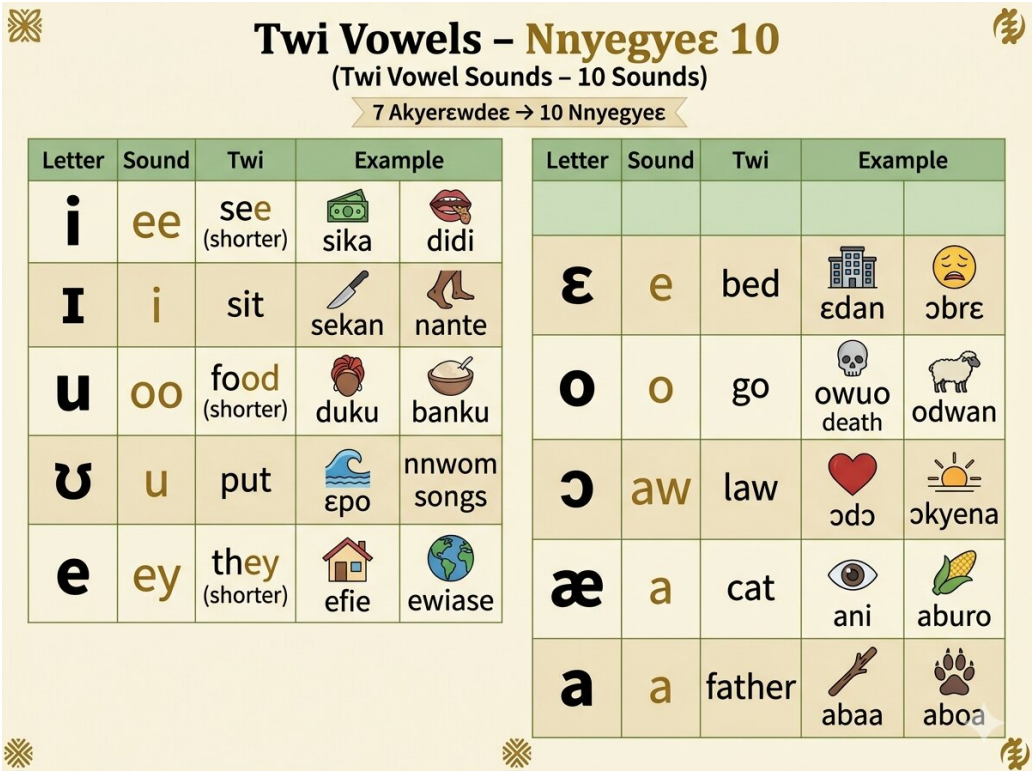

Figure 2: Twi Vowels – 10 Sounds, 7 Written Letters

Advancement of the Tongue Root

You might notice that some vowels feel "lighter" and some feel "heavier" in your mouth. That's because of something called Advanced Tongue Root (ATR) – but you don't need to remember that fancy term!

Just remember this simple rule:

- **+ATR (Light vowels)**: i, u, e, o, æ – feel bright and forward in your mouth
- **-ATR (Heavy vowels)**: ɪ, ʊ, ɛ, ɔ, a, feel deeper and more relaxed

Why this matters: In Twi, vowels in a word usually come from the same group. This is called **vowel harmony**, and you've already learned it!

Example: *efie* (house) uses light vowels • *sekan* (knife) uses heavy vowels
See how they feel different in your mouth?

Twi Consonants – Anom nnyegyeeɛ

Now let's learn all the consonant sounds in Twi. Don't worry, many of them are just like English!

Simple Consonants (15 Sounds)

These 15 consonants sound very similar to their English cousins. You already know most of them!

Letter	Sounds Like	Twi Word	Meaning
b	b in "boy"	banku	banku (food)
d	d in "dog"	din	name
f	f in "fun"	fie	house
g	g in "go"	galɔn	gallon
h	h in "hat"	hama	rope
k	k in "key"	kanea	lamp
l	l in "love"	lɔre	lorry
m	m in "man"	amango	mango
n	n in "no"	nana	grandparent
p	p in "pen"	praeɛ	broom
r	r in "run" (lightly rolled)	rɔba	rubber
s	s in "sun"	sika	money
t	t in "top"	atadeɛ	dress
w	w in "win"	waduro	mortar
y	y in "yes"	yoma	camel

A Note on R: The Twi 'r' is lighter than English – tap your tongue quickly, like the 'tt' in "butter" (American accent).

Quick Practice: Say these words 3 times each – *banku, din, fie, sika, nana*

Consonant Blends / Digraphs (9 Sounds)

These are written with TWO letters but make ONE sound. Think of English ”ch” and ”sh”, same idea!

Pair	Pronunciation	Twi Word	Meaning
dw	like ”jw” in ”Jwɛ”	edwam	market
gy	like ”j” in ”jam”	gyata	lion
hy	like ”sh” but with extra air	hyɛ	wear
hw	like ”hw” in ”where”	hwɛ	look
kw	like ”kw” in ”quick”	kwadu	banana
ky	like ”ch” in ”cheese”	ɛkyɛ	share
ny	like ”ny” in ”canyon”	nyaadowa	garden eggs
nw	nasal ”nw” – say ”n” + ”w” together	nwa	snail
tw	like ”chw” (say ”ch” + ”w”)	twerɛ	write

Practice Words. Say Them 5 Times Each!

edwam (market) **gyata** (lion) **hyɛ** (wear)
hwɛ (look) **kwadu** (banana) **ɛkyɛ** (share)
nyaadowa (garden eggs) **nwa** (snail) **twerɛ** (write)

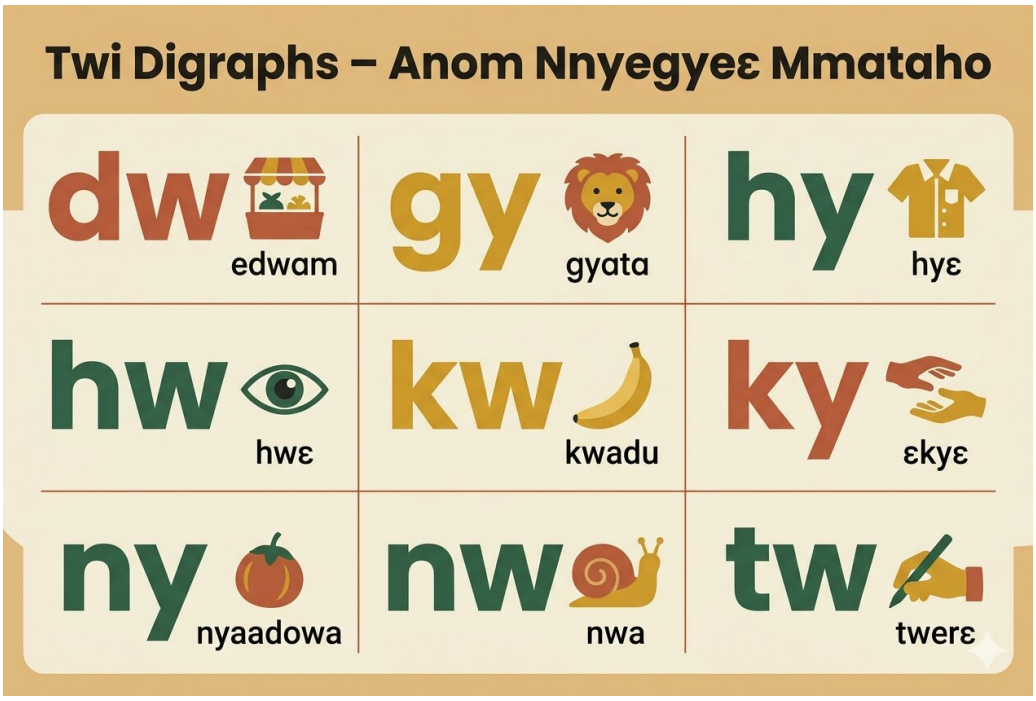

Figure 3: Special Consonant Pairs – 9 Sounds in Twi

Fun Fact

Many of these special sounds don’t exist in English, which is why they feel tricky at first. But your mouth will learn with practice!

Pro Tip: Watch Ghanaian movies or listen to music and try to hear these sounds. Your brain will start recognizing them naturally!

All 24 Consonants at a Glance

b	d	f	g	h	k
l	m	n	p	r	s
t	w	y	dw	gy	hy
hw	kw	ky	ny	nw	tw

Count them – that's 24! You've learned them all.

Building Words with Syllables

Now that you know the letters and sounds, let's learn how to put them together to make words!

The Simple Rule

Most Twi syllables follow a simple pattern:

Consonant + Vowel = Syllable

For example: **bra** (come), **me** (I), **kɔ** (go), **di** (eat)

Building Words from Syllables

When you put two syllables together, you get a longer word:

Syllable 1	Syllable 2	= Word (Meaning)
pa	pa	= papa (father / good)
ka	sa	= kasa (speak / language)
su	kuu	= sukuu (school)

Words That Start with a Vowel

Some words start with a vowel alone, then add syllables:

Word	Breakdown
akwaaba (welcome)	a + kwaa + ba
ɔdɔ (love)	ɔ + dɔ
ani (eye)	a + ni

Words with Nasal Sounds

The letters **m** and **n** can stand alone as syllables:

Word	Breakdown
mpa (bed)	m + pa
nsu (water)	n + su
nsa (hand)	n + sa

Key Insight

Remember: Once you know the syllables, you can build ANY word in Twi. It's like LEGO – learn the small blocks, then build bigger words!

Words with Digraphs

Digraphs are two letters that make ONE sound (like ky, gy, ny, dw, tw). They act as a single consonant in a syllable.

Word	Breakdown
gyeene (onion)	gye + ne
agya (father)	a + gya
nyansa (sense / wisdom)	nyan + sa
adwuma (work)	a + dwu + ma
nwi (hair)	nwi

Key Insight

Remember: Digraphs like *gy*, *ny*, *dw*, *tw*, *ky* are treated as ONE sound, not two separate letters. Practice them until they feel natural!

Coming up in Week 2: You will use these syllables to form real greetings, like *me ma wo akye* (good morning)!

Chapter Summary: What You've Learned

- The complete Twi alphabet (22 letters)
- Special letters Ɛ and Ɔ and their sounds
- 10 vowel sounds (7 written letters)
- 15 simple consonants

- 9 consonant blends/digraphs
- How to pronounce each letter with examples
- Vowel harmony (light vs heavy vowels)
- Cultural notes on language learning

Kɔ so sua! – Keep learning!
You've learned the building blocks of Twi. Next, we'll put these letters together to form syllables and words!
Coming up next: Greetings and Self Introduction

Reconnect. Speak. Thrive.

Speak Ghana Language School
www.speakghana.org
WhatsApp: +233 55 226 3323

Yɛn toa so! – Let's continue!